

THE SOFTEN SOUL



Understanding Grief and Loss

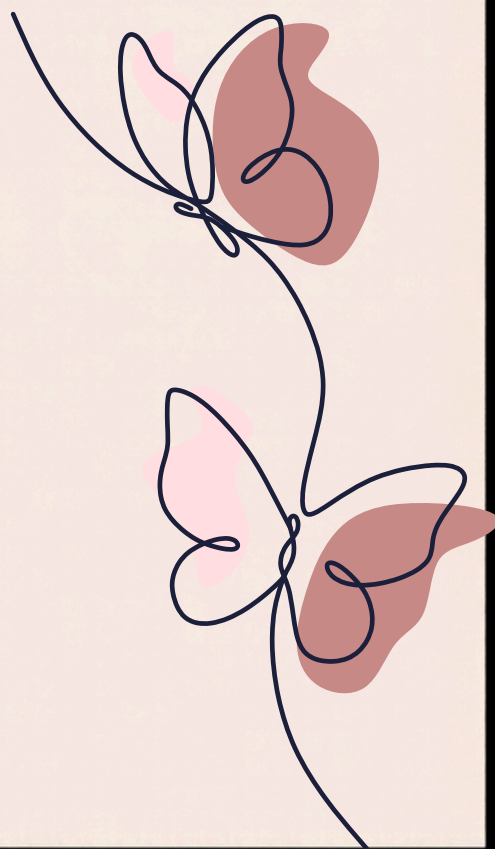
A Gentle Guide

A space to notice, reflect,
and honor what you carry.

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DEDICATION

This guide is dedicated to my daughter, Alissa.

Honoring my grief taught me to love more deeply and live more fully.



Forever, My Angel

For those navigating loss

If this guide has found its way to you, grief may have touched your life through loss, change, or a quiet absence that is hard to explain. This space was created as a gentle place to meet grief without judgment or expectation.

There is no right way to move through these pages, only an invitation to listen to yourself with care. I chose to speak openly about grief because it is a deeply human experience that can be difficult to talk about.

I have seen, and lived, how lonely grief can feel when it is dismissed or minimized. Naming grief is not about staying stuck in pain. It is about giving ourselves permission to acknowledge what is real and meet it with compassion.

During our Heart Chakra work, we explored how grief, loss, love, fear, and emotional wounds can live alongside one another. This guide gives you space to continue that reflection privately and at your own pace.

A GENTLE REMINDER

Pause when memories surface or emotions rise. There is nothing to complete or fix here. Notice, reflect, and honor your grief in its own time.

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*Begin wherever you need to.
You are welcome to return.*

01

What is grief

*Grief is a natural response
to loss.*

There is no right way to feel

Grief is a natural response to loss. If you are reading this, it may be because something meaningful has been lost.

Grief can affect emotions, thoughts, energy, and your sense of identity. Some days it is loud. Other days it is quiet. You may notice tears, exhaustion, irritability, numbness, or difficulty concentrating.

Grief is not limited to death. It can follow:

- The loss of a loved one
- The end of a relationship
- Changes in health or ability
- Identity shifts
- Loss of safety, dreams, or expectations
- Life transitions such as divorce, relocation, or retirement

This guide is not here to fix you or your grief. It is here to help you recognize what you may be carrying, with kindness and without judgment.

*Grief does not move in a straight line.
There is no timeline you are supposed to follow.*

02

Why grief feels so hard to carry

*Your experience deserves room,
even when it is difficult to explain.*

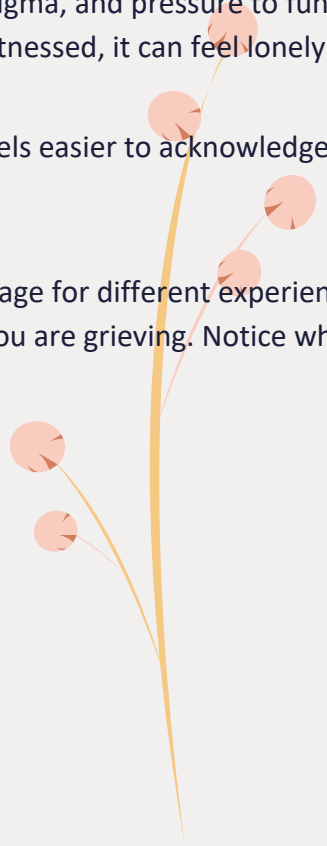
When grief is given space

Grief can feel heavier when it is not acknowledged. Many people are taught to stay strong, move on, or keep their pain private. You deserve room for your experience, whether you express it openly or keep it close.

Cultural expectations, family roles, stigma, and pressure to function can make grieving feel unsafe or inconvenient. When grief is not witnessed, it can feel lonely and overwhelming.

There may be moments when grief feels easier to acknowledge, and moments when it feels harder. You do not have to force either one.

The following descriptions offer language for different experiences of loss. They are not stages, diagnoses, or measures of how well you are grieving. Notice what resonates, and leave what does not.



*Seeing your experience
reflected in language
can invite a little more
compassion.*

Loss can take many forms

— Abbreviated grief

Grief may feel shorter or less intense for some people. This does not mean the loss mattered less. Grieving before a loss does not necessarily make grief afterward shorter.

Example: You feel sadness without the shock you expected.

Reflection: What has your own experience of grief been like?

— Ambiguous loss

There may be no clear ending or certainty. A person or situation may still be present, but changed or unresolved.

Example: Someone is still here, but not in the way they once were.

Reflection: What feels unfinished or unclear for you right now?

— Anticipatory grief

Grief may begin before a loss occurs, while caring for someone or facing a change you know is coming.

Example: You are still loving and showing up, while quietly grieving what may change.

Reflection: What are you already mourning as you look ahead?

What else are you carrying?

— Collective grief

Grief can be shared within a community after a shared loss or social, racial, or political harm.

Example: Events affecting your community leave you worn down, even when nothing happened directly to you.

Reflection: How has shared pain been showing up in daily life?

— Common grief responses

Sadness, anger, relief, confusion, longing, and moments of peace can come and go. Several feelings may exist together.

Example: Some days you cry easily. Other days you feel steady.

Reflection: What emotions have been visiting you lately?

— Secondary grief

Losses can follow a primary loss, including changes in routine, identity, relationships, or stability.

Example: Alongside the main loss, your rhythms or support system shift too.

Reflection: What else has changed that others might not notice?

You have not failed

Grief does not move in a straight line. Your experience may shift over time, and some days may still feel very hard.

If grief feels persistent or overwhelming, it does not mean you have done something wrong. Many factors shape how we experience loss.

Support can offer space to explore what you are carrying. You do not have to wait until you can explain it perfectly.

If grief is making daily life difficult, a qualified mental health professional can help you understand what you are experiencing and discuss support.

*You deserve care,
including on the difficult days.*

Meeting yourself with care

— Absent grief

You may notice little outward emotion, numbness, or a sense of distance. This does not tell the whole story of what you are experiencing.

Example: People expect tears, but you feel flat or disconnected.

Reflection: Where do you notice numbness or distance?

— Persistent, intense grief

Grief can remain intense and disrupt daily life. A qualified mental health professional can assess your experience, including whether prolonged grief disorder may be relevant after a death. This guide does not diagnose it.

Example: Time has passed, but the pain still feels close and disruptive.

Reflection: How is grief affecting your day-to-day life?

— Compounded (cumulative) grief

Several losses can leave little room to adjust between them.

Example: Before you have had space to breathe after one loss, another arrives.

Reflection: What losses have stacked up for you?

Feelings may arrive differently

— Delayed grief

Feelings connected to a loss may become noticeable later, sometimes when life slows down or circumstances change.

Example: You focused on getting through at first. Later, emotions surface.

Reflection: What feelings are showing up now?

— Overwhelming grief

Grief may feel consuming or difficult to carry. The intensity of your feelings does not make them excessive or wrong.

Example: Pain takes up much of your attention or disrupts your sleep.

Reflection: Where does grief feel too heavy to carry alone?

— Inhibited grief

You may hold emotions inside to keep functioning or to protect others.

Example: You stay busy, composed, or “fine” because slowing down feels difficult.

Reflection: What feelings have you been holding back in order to cope?

Notice what is here

Masked grief

Sometimes loss may be part of what you are carrying even when sadness is not the first feeling you notice. You may feel tense, exhausted, or irritable and wonder whether loss is part of the picture.

Physical symptoms can have other causes, too.
Seek medical advice for symptoms that concern you.

Your insights

You may feel open one moment and withdrawn the next. That is not failure. These descriptions are invitations to reflect, not fixed categories. You do not need a label that fits.

What words, questions, or insights would you like to carry with you?



03

Common ways people grieve

*Your way of grieving
may change over time.*



There is room for your way

There are many ways to grieve. Your responses may change across losses and over time. These descriptions are invitations to notice, not boxes you need to fit into.

Instrumental grieving

You may process grief through doing, problem-solving, or practical tasks. Feelings may also emerge privately or during activities such as walking.

Dissonant grieving

There may be a gap between what you feel and what you feel able to express. Family expectations, cultural norms, or concern about burdening others can shape that gap.

Intuitive grieving

You may process grief through talking, crying, or sharing cherished memories. These expressions do not mean you feel loss more deeply than someone who grieves differently. These patterns come from the work of Terry Martin and Kenneth Doka.



REFLECTION

1. Do you feel drawn to express emotions, focus on practical tasks, or reflect quietly?
2. Have these responses changed over time or across different losses?

The Grief We Carry

Research shows Black Americans face many of these losses earlier and more often, and Black women are often expected to carry them quietly.

— Child loss

Losing a child, whether a baby or a grown son or daughter, changes how you carry everything else. You are not wrong for needing more than a week, or a year.

Example: You went back to work before you were ready, and everyone called it strength.

Reflection: Who has asked you about your child, and not just how you are holding up?

— Loss of a mother

Losing your mother, early or late, can leave you mothering everyone else before you have had a chance to miss her. Many mothers are also lost around childbirth, which leaves daughters, sisters, and nanas behind.

Example: You became the mama to your younger siblings the week she passed.

Reflection: What did you have to put down when you picked everyone else up?

— Loss of a loved one to incarceration

When someone you love is alive but gone, there is no funeral and no casserole, and people may judge the loss instead of grieving it with you. You do not have to carry it quietly.

Example: You drive four hours on a Saturday, and people ask what he did, not how you are.

Reflection: Where can you be tender about this without being judged?

The Grief We Carry, continued

— Disenfranchised grief

Some losses are not recognized by the people around you, and you may be expected to feel relieved instead. You can grieve a relationship that hurt you, and still miss what it was or what you hoped it would be.

Example: You are grieving the end of a relationship that was hard on you, and your friends tell you to get over it or be happy it is over.

Reflection: Where are you being asked to feel something other than what is true for you?

— Identity grief

Sometimes what you are grieving is her: the woman you were before the loss, or the one you were never allowed to be. When so much of who you are is holding everyone up, losing that role can feel like losing yourself.

Example: You do not know who you are when no one needs you to be the strong one.

Reflection: What part of you has not been allowed to rest?

— Intergenerational grief

Some of what you carry began long before you. Our families lived through enormous loss, and many learned to survive by holding it in. That grief can reach you through stories, through silences, and through the way the women before you taught you to be strong.

Example: Your grandmother never spoke about the sister she lost, and your mother learned not to ask. Now you cry over things you can't explain, and you wonder whose tears they are.

Reflection: What grief in your family was never spoken aloud?

What our family members passed down

Many of us learned early that tears were not safe to show.

Our family members passed down what had kept them going, and often that meant staying composed and moving on. The lesson comes from generations of hard history.

It was love and it was protection. It may also have cost you something.

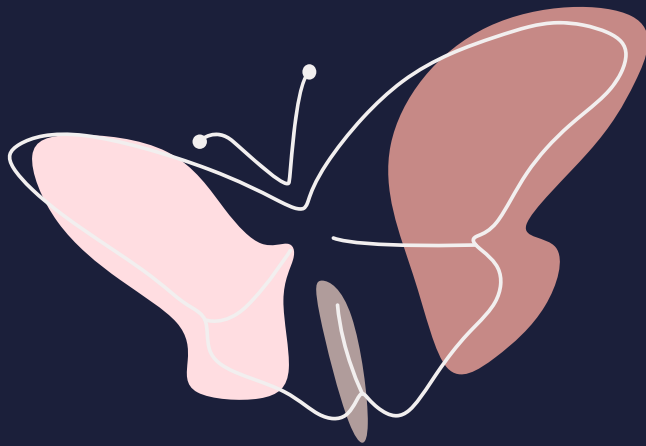
Example: Your mother stood at the funeral with her back straight and her face still, and told you to do the same. You are grown now, and you still excuse yourself to cry in the car.

Reflection: What did the family members around you do with their tears?

You can honor what kept them safe and still let yourself cry.

04

Myths about grief



*Your grief does not need
to be compared to be valid.*

Making space beyond the myths

“Time heals all wounds.”

Time alone does not guarantee grief will ease. Support, care, and room to adjust can matter, too.

“Stay strong.”

You do not have to hide your pain to be strong. You can be honest about what hurts and what you need.

“Don’t cry.”

Tears are one way to express emotion. Crying and not crying are both possible responses; neither measures how deeply you care.

“They’re in a better place.”

Spiritual beliefs may bring comfort while longing, absence, and love remain. Both can be true.

“At least...”

Comparisons can minimize a loss. Your grief deserves acknowledgment without needing to be reframed.

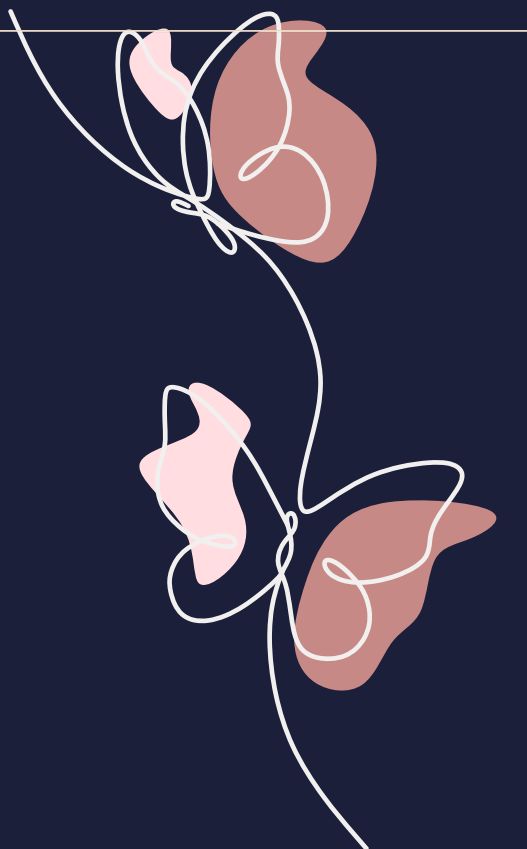
“You should be over this.”

Dates, memories, and life changes can bring grief into focus again. Needing support is not a failure.

05

Healing through grief

*Learning to live alongside
what has changed.*



You do not have to carry it alone

Sometimes what is needed most is not advice or solutions, but space. Space to breathe, to be honest, and to notice what you are feeling.

Support does not mean fixing your grief or moving on from it. It means being met with understanding, steadiness, and care while you learn to live alongside what has changed.

Support can offer

- Space to name what you feel without judgment
- Relief from carrying everything on your own
- Gentle grounding when emotions feel overwhelming
- A reminder that you do not have to rush or explain your grief
- Support as you learn to live alongside loss

*You are welcome to make room for grief,
at your own pace.*

A gentle next step

If parts of this guide have resonated, consider this a pause rather than a push.

You may want more space to reflect, more understanding of your experience, or simply reassurance that you do not have to carry this alone.

If you would like, you are welcome to:

- Sit with what you have read and move at your own pace.
- Explore The Soften Soul and the support currently available.
- Reach out with a question when you feel ready.

STAY CONNECTED

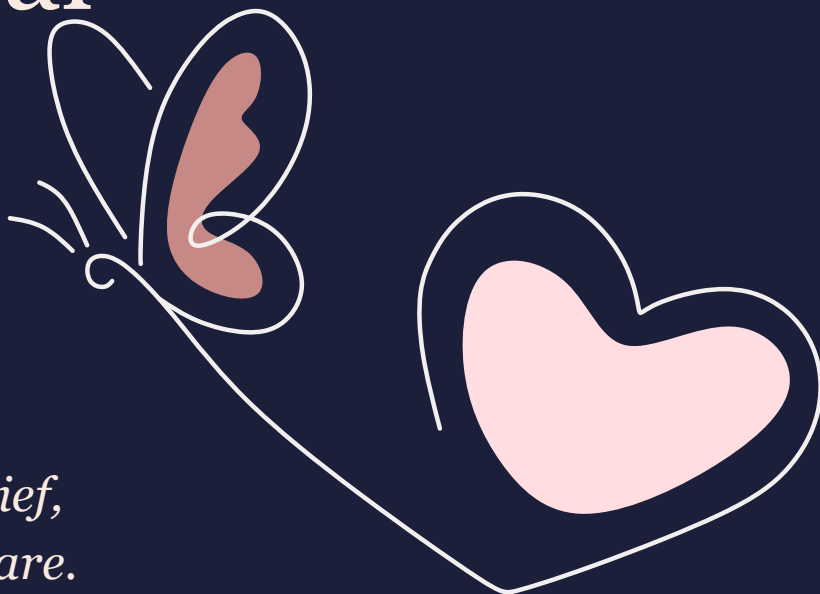
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There is no next step you are expected to take.

06

Holding space as you heal

*Walking alongside grief,
with steadiness and care.*



A compassionate presence

You may wonder whether having someone walk alongside you would feel supportive. Your grief does not have to be “big enough,” recent enough, or visible enough to deserve care.

A grief coach is not a therapist and does not replace medical or mental health care. A grief coach offers presence, education, and compassionate support through loss and life transitions, with room to move at your own pace.

Support may feel welcome when...

- You feel emotionally tired or quietly hold a lot.
- Your grief feels misunderstood or difficult to explain.
- You function outwardly but struggle internally.
- You are navigating a life transition shaped by loss.

What working together can look like

- One-on-one grief support and gentle education
- Optional grounding practices when emotions feel heavy
- Support around anniversaries, transitions, and identity shifts
- A consistent, compassionate presence

My approach makes room for how loss is experienced emotionally, physically, and in your sense of self. There are no stages to complete or timelines to follow. We move with care, without trying to hurry your grief.

Closing reflections

As you come to the end of this guide, there is nothing you are meant to complete or resolve. Grief moves at its own pace, and simply bringing awareness to what you carry is meaningful.

You may feel softer, clearer, or more present with your experience, or you may feel uncertain. All of it belongs.

Support, when you choose it, is a way of honoring your grief, whether through reflection, trusted connection, or working alongside a grief coach.

This guide can remain a place to return whenever you need grounding, permission, or a gentle reminder that your grief deserves care and respect.

*Your grief deserves care.
So do you.*



THE SOFTEN SOUL

About this work

I hold space for souls experiencing grief to feel safe, supported, and nurtured as their hearts heal. My work is shaped by lived experience of grief that is often misunderstood or minimized.

This guide offers language for grief and loss in their many forms, with room for each person's experience. Naming what we carry can be an invitation to meet it with care.

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WHEN YOU ARE READY

thesoftensoul.com

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Sources

These are the studies and books behind the pages on the grief we carry.

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